A PASTOR CAN BE KNOWN AND STILL UNSUPPORTED.

People can know your name, hear your sermons, and depend on your leadership without knowing what you carry.

Visibility can hide isolation. Recognition and support are not the same. A Pastor may be surrounded by people, appreciated by the church, and still have no safe place to speak honestly or share the weight.

The figures offer both recognition and a question. To the Pastor who feels alone: **you are not the only one.** To the church: do the people around the role truly know the person carrying it?

Who knows the soul beneath your role?

Jesus named His sorrow

In Gethsemane, as Jesus moved toward the cross, He named His sorrow, brought Peter, James, and John closer, and asked them to keep watch. They did not respond well, but His willingness to ask for their presence was not weakness.

Jesus shows us that **honest sorrow and faithful obedience are not opposites.**

That matters because privacy and isolation are not the same. Every Pastor needs trustworthy, godly people who are close enough to see clearly, speak honestly, ask hard questions, and challenge them in love.

> **"Therefore, a Christian needs another Christian who speaks God's Word to him."**
>
> Dietrich Bonhoeffer | Life Together

Some of the healthiest people for that role may be outside the congregation. Transparency does not mean telling everything to everyone. It means having the right people who know what is true and have permission to speak into your life.

Those relationships must also become places of prayer, not only places to talk. Together we come before the Father, listen to Jesus through His Word, and ask the Holy Spirit to bring truth, comfort, conviction, and direction. We cannot manufacture real life change. God does that work.

The weight can be shared without diminishing the calling

When Moses' hands grew tired, Aaron and Hur gave him a place to sit and held his hands steady while Joshua led the people in battle. Each person carried a distinct part.

The calling may be personal, but the weight does not have to be carried alone.

The early church made this kind of care practical around Paul. The Philippian church shared in his troubles, sent help more than once, and sent people to care for his needs. Other believers stayed close enough to accompany him and share the weight. Care was not an idea: they stayed close, sent help, and shared responsibility.

Compassion takes different forms.

No act of compassion is too small to matter. No burden is so great that the body of Christ should look away. We may not be able to carry all of it, but we can faithfully carry our part.

Care will not look the same in every season. Some will hold up the Pastor's arms. Some will take on responsibilities the Pastor has been carrying alone. Some will bring resources or create room for rest. Some will cover the pulpit, make the phone calls, provide the meals, or simply remain close when the road becomes difficult.

A Pastor is called to shepherd the congregation, and the congregation is also called to care for those who shepherd them. As people respond to Christ's calling on their lives, they begin to notice, encourage, strengthen, and help carry one another, including their Pastor.

> **"When we struggle privately, we compensate in the way we lead."**
>
> Andy Stanley | Courage in Leadership

Not every weight belongs on the Pastor's shoulders simply because they have been willing to carry it.

Questions worth sitting with

1. Who knows the Pastor well enough to encourage them, ask hard questions, and challenge them in love? Are there trustworthy people outside the congregation who should be part of that circle?
2. Which responsibilities are concentrated in the pastoral role? Which belong there, which could be shared, and what authority, preparation, or resources would make that transfer healthy?
3. Where do we need to pause and pray together before deciding what support or change is needed? What practical act of care can follow that prayer now, before a crisis forces the question?

Putting this into practice

Begin with prayer and one safe, honest conversation. Gather the Pastor and those who share responsibility for the church. Come before the Father, listen to Jesus through His Word, and ask the Holy Spirit to show what is true and what faithful care requires. Return to prayer when hard truths surface and before deciding the next step.

Then ask what would help and what weight can be shared. The response may be protected rest, peer support, counseling, pulpit coverage, a changed schedule, ending needless work, or placing responsibility into capable hands. Agree on who will act, what support they need, and when you will check back.

We cannot manufacture life change. God does that work. Caring for a Pastor is one way the body of Christ responds faithfully and cares for its own.

Moving into the next chapter

Support asks whether the Pastor has people who can see clearly, pray faithfully, speak honestly, and challenge in love. Next, we ask who is being formed and trusted to share the work.

That brings us to Who Are You Bringing With You?

Presenter notes

- Let people examine the visual before explaining the statistics. Ask what they notice and where they feel tension.
- Say plainly that the Barna figures are separate survey measures, not a diagnosis, progression, or mathematical contrast. Their purpose here is recognition and conversation, not shock.
- Pray with the Pastor and staff before the evaluation begins, when difficult truths surface, and before deciding the next step. Come before the Father, listen to Jesus through His Word, and ask the Holy Spirit to lead. Do not use prayer to rush disclosure, silence disagreement, or avoid necessary action.
- Keep the conversation from becoming another assignment for the Pastor. The board, staff, volunteers, and congregation should ask what part Christ is calling them to carry.
- Do not pressure a Pastor to disclose pain publicly. Privacy is not isolation, and transparency does not mean telling everything to everyone. Encourage trustworthy, godly relationships that can include honest challenge and may appropriately exist outside the congregation.
- Honor the Pastor's faithfulness without making overwork untouchable. A willingness to carry weight does not prove that the weight still belongs on the Pastor's shoulders.
- Invite concrete care. “We appreciate you” is meaningful, but appreciation is not the same as rest, friendship, shared responsibility, spiritual support, or a safe place to tell the truth.
- Keep the two supporting quotations visually and theologically subordinate to Scripture. Bonhoeffer supports the mutual need within Christian community. Stanley names a leadership consequence of keeping struggle hidden.

Scripture and content boundaries

- **Mark 14:32-42:** In Gethsemane, as Jesus moved toward the cross, He named His sorrow, brought Peter, James, and John farther into the garden, and asked them to keep watch. Keep the application centered on Jesus' honest sorrow and His willingness to ask for their presence; do not compare a Pastor's calling with Christ's unique work.
- **John 16:13-15:** Jesus teaches that the Spirit of truth guides and glorifies Him. Dependence on the Holy Spirit should keep the process centered on Christ rather than making the group more confident in its own opinions.
- **Exodus 17:8-13:** Aaron and Hur held up Moses' hands, while Joshua led the people in battle. The passage shows distinct people carrying different parts; it should not be used to place Moses or a modern Pastor beyond accountability.
- **Philippians 2:25-30; 4:14-18:** The Philippian church shared in Paul's troubles, sent aid more than once, and sent someone to care for his needs.
- **Acts 20:4; 27:2; Colossians 4:10:** A believer from Thessalonica accompanied Paul and was later identified as his fellow prisoner. This supports the example of individual care; do not state that the entire Thessalonian church served Paul in prison.
- **1 Thessalonians 5:11-14; Galatians 6:2:** These passages ground mutual encouragement, help for the weak, patience, and shared burdens. Read the passages from a Bible rather than presenting our application as a quotation from Scripture.
- The 1-3-12 language is a relational principle, not a ranking system or a required headcount. The fuller explanation belongs in the next chapter.

Sources

- Barna Group. “7-Year Trends: Pastors Feel More Loneliness & Less Support.” July 12, 2023. Displayed figures: 2022 survey of 585 U.S. Protestant senior Pastors.
- Bonhoeffer, Dietrich. Life Together. Hymns Ancient and Modern Ltd., 2012 Kindle edition, locations 116-121.
- Stanley, Andy. “From the Vault: Courage in Leadership.” Andy Stanley Leadership Podcast, August 2023.